

How to Choose an AI Visibility Partner: 7 Questions to Ask First

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GEO and AEO agencies are multiplying faster than the discipline itself has matured, and a lot of what's being sold is hype wearing new acronyms. Here are the 7 questions worth asking before you hire anyone — and what the honest answers actually sound like.

Quick Answer

Choosing an AI visibility partner comes down to seven concrete questions: can they show real, verifiable results rather than vague claims; do they build durable technical and entity infrastructure or just publish content; do they measure success with real search and AI-citation data instead of vanity metrics; is the work reproducible without permanent dependence on them; do they understand your specific market and vertical; do they set a realistic, explained timeline rather than promising overnight results; and who actually does the work — a named person or an anonymous team. A vendor who can answer all seven directly, with specifics rather than generalities, is far more likely to deliver durable AI visibility than one selling urgency and jargon.

The category is new, and that cuts both ways

Generative Engine Optimization is young enough that there's no established licensing, no industry-standard certification, and no long track record to check the way you might check a traditional marketing agency's client list. That's part of what makes it exciting — nobody has a decade of stale playbooks to unlearn — and part of what makes it risky. Agencies are relabeling old SEO and content-marketing services with GEO and AEO terminology faster than the underlying discipline has actually matured, and it is genuinely difficult from the outside to tell the difference between a partner who has built real technical and entity infrastructure and one who has simply updated their pitch deck.

The good news is that the difference shows up clearly in how a vendor answers a small number of specific, concrete questions. Vague or evasive answers are the tell — not the absence of an answer, but the shape of it.

Question 1: Can you show real, verifiable results?

Ask for actual before-and-after numbers from real engagements — search impressions, ranking keyword counts, AI citation data, review growth — not just testimonial quotes or screenshots without context. A credible partner should be comfortable sharing specific, dated figures, even anonymized, and should be able to explain where each number comes from — Google Search Console, a rank-tracking tool, AI visibility monitoring — rather than presenting an unsourced dashboard screenshot.

Be specific in what you ask for: not "do you get results," but "show me the actual month-over-month search impression numbers for a client in a similar starting position to mine."

Question 2: Are they building infrastructure, or just publishing content?

GEO and AEO work that lasts is built on technical and entity foundations — structured data, entity architecture, site health, internal linking — with content published on top of that foundation. Work that's just a content calendar with AI-sounding topics, and no technical or entity component underneath, tends to plateau early, because it never addresses the structural signals AI engines actually evaluate.

Ask directly: "Walk me through what happens in month one, before any content gets published." A partner doing real infrastructure work will have a concrete answer — technical audits, schema implementation, entity verification. A partner without one will often pivot straight to describing blog topics.

Question 3: How do they measure success?

Some vendors report on metrics that feel impressive but don't map to actual visibility — total word count published, number of "AI mentions" with no context on sentiment or accuracy, generic traffic numbers that don't distinguish branded from non-branded search. The metrics that actually matter are the ones tied to specific, verifiable outcomes: search impressions and clicks from Google Search Console, ranking keyword growth, AI citation volume and sentiment from AI visibility monitoring, and local pack or map presence where relevant.

If a proposed reporting structure doesn't include at least these categories, ask why — and be cautious of a vendor who can't clearly explain what each number they report actually measures.

Question 4: Is the work reproducible without permanent dependence on them?

Some of the value in this work is genuinely infrastructure — schema, entity architecture, technical fixes — that continues working after an engagement ends, the same way a well-built website keeps functioning after the web developer moves on. Some vendors structure their offering so that stopping the engagement causes visibility to collapse, because the "optimization" was really just continuous manual intervention rather than durable infrastructure.

Ask what happens to your search and AI visibility if you paused the engagement after a year. An honest answer acknowledges that ongoing content and monitoring add continued value, while the technical and entity foundation remains in place independently.

Question 5: Do they understand your specific market?

Generic GEO advice — "publish more content," "get more reviews," "add schema markup" — is true but insufficiently specific to actually move results. A partner who understands your vertical should be able to speak concretely about the actual questions your buyers ask AI engines, the specific competitive landscape in your market, and how AI engines are already representing your category, not just your business.

A useful test: ask what an AI engine currently says when asked about your category in your specific market, before any work has started. A partner who has actually researched your situation will have a real answer; one who hasn't will speak only in generalities.

Question 6: Is the timeline realistic, and do they explain why?

AI visibility work compounds — it rarely produces dramatic results in the first thirty days, and a vendor promising otherwise is either inexperienced or overselling. A credible partner should be able to explain, in specific terms, why their timeline looks the way it does: technical foundation work typically comes first and isn't visible externally, followed by content and entity signals that compound over several months, followed by visible ranking and citation growth once a credibility threshold is crossed.

Be skeptical of both extremes — a vendor promising results in weeks, and one who can't commit to any timeline framework at all.

Question 7: Who actually does the work?

In a category this new, a meaningful amount of "AI visibility" work is still done by real people making real strategic decisions — not a fully automated black box. Ask who specifically will be working on your account, what their background is, and whether the person you're talking to during the sales process is involved in the actual work or hands off to an anonymous team afterward.

This isn't about needing a celebrity strategist — it's about accountability. A vendor who can't tell you who does the work, or treats the question as unusual, is a signal worth taking seriously.

Red flags worth naming directly

A few patterns are worth flagging on their own, regardless of how the seven questions above are answered: guaranteed rankings or guaranteed AI citations (no legitimate partner can guarantee outcomes on platforms they don't control); pricing based purely on volume of content published rather than outcomes measured; reporting that only ever shows positive numbers with no visible baseline or comparison period; and reluctance to put deliverables, timelines, or reporting cadence in writing before you sign.

What a well-run engagement actually looks like

In practice, a credible engagement usually follows a recognizable shape: an initial technical and entity audit in month one, with concrete, itemized findings rather than a generic checklist; visible technical and structural fixes in the first month or two, even before content ramps up; a content and entity strategy grounded in your actual market's real buyer questions, not generic templates; monthly reporting tied to Search Console, rank tracking, and AI visibility data with clear before-and-after comparisons; and a growth curve that compounds over months rather than spiking once and flattening.

Frequently Asked Questions

How much should AI visibility or GEO services cost?

Pricing varies widely by market, scope, and starting point, but the more useful question is what's included at a given price — technical infrastructure work and entity architecture cost more to do properly than a pure content calendar, and a price that seems unusually low relative to competitors often means one of those foundational components is missing.

How long should I commit to before expecting results?

Most credible engagements set expectations around a 3 to 8 month window before major visibility milestones, because technical and entity groundwork typically needs to compound before results become visible. Be cautious of both a vendor promising results in under a month and one who won't commit to any realistic timeframe at all.

Should I ask for references from current clients?

Yes, and specifically ask to see real, dated performance data rather than just a testimonial quote — a vendor confident in their results should be comfortable sharing anonymized but specific numbers, not just satisfied-sounding language.

What's the biggest mistake businesses make when choosing an AI visibility partner?

Choosing based on how confidently a vendor uses AI-search terminology rather than on concrete evidence of technical and entity work. GEO and AEO vocabulary is easy to learn and repeat; building the underlying infrastructure that actually earns AI citations is the harder, less easily faked part.

Can I do AI visibility work myself instead of hiring a partner?

Some of it, yes — publishing direct-answer content, adding basic FAQ schema, and claiming your Google Business Profile are all things a business owner can do directly. The harder parts to do without support are typically the technical entity architecture, ongoing AI visibility monitoring across multiple platforms, and the market-specific strategy that comes from having worked across many similar engagements.

CONCLUSION

The honest answer to most of these seven questions takes longer to give than a confident, vague one — which is exactly why they're useful filters. A partner willing to show real numbers, explain their technical foundation, set a realistic timeline, and tell you plainly who does the work is behaving like someone building durable infrastructure. A partner who deflects two or three of these questions with reassurance instead of specifics is very likely selling a version of GEO that won't hold up past the first few months.